

lowed in other industries as well, such as food delivery.

The Indian entertainment industry is in a transformative phase right now; digital has stormed the bastion, questioning every existing business model and making it impossible to predict tomorrow. As the business gets redefined, it's not just about films anymore. Mani goes as far as to say that digital solutions "will be as seamless and accessible as electricity is today". Just at the click of a button, it seems.

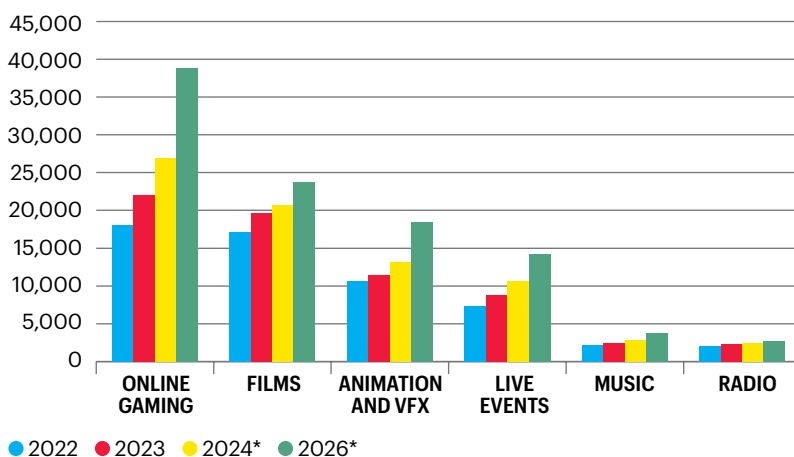
SIT BACK AND ENJOY

Entertainment in a new India has taken several forms—films in a new look, sports, fantasy games, music, and live events, to name a few. A conversation on box-office collections runs the risk of becoming redundant. Now, it is about time on hand to consume media against the multiple available options. The consumer is spoilt for choice.

While it is known that 1,800 films released across languages last year, or that more than 600 million watched the IPL on streaming, did you know that India had over 450 million gamers, of which Dream11 alone accounts for over 220 million? The number has grown from just 17 million in 2018. Vikrant Mudaliar, Chief Marketing Officer of fantasy sports platform Dream11 thinks the 'daily fantasy game' format was a big breakthrough compared to the traditional season-long fantasy. "It was a consumer behaviour that revolved around limited time and the need for instant gratification. Plus, lower data prices meant a surge in users," he says. Dream11 has been associated with the IP of online gaming for over a decade. "Fantasy sports has evoked high levels of

SUSTAINED GROWTH

● The online gaming industry is expected to reach ₹38,800 crore by 2026, according to a report by EY



*ESTIMATES **NOTE** ALL FIGURES REPRESENT REVENUE IN ₹ CRORE
SOURCE FICCI-EY MEDIA AND ENTERTAINMENT REPORT 2023

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interest by being at the cross-section of sports, gaming, technology, and entertainment. All of that in an app makes it a hugely interesting proposition," says Mudaliar.

Add to that, audiences are getting more segmented and demanding. "A live event could well be enjoyed in the comfort of one's home. That kind of an immersive experience is very much a possibility with the advent of technology," says Chandrashekar Mantha, Partner and Media Sector Leader at Deloitte India. He believes India could become the VFX, or visual effects factory to the world.

C FOR CHOICE

Mainstream forms of entertainment have not always been accessible by the mass but over-the-top, or OTT, services have changed that. For instance, choosing a vernacular language for a cricket match or

watching a movie when you want are just a couple of the multitude of choices available. Entertainment in a post-pandemic world is unrecognisable because of OTTs.

Mani points out that there are three key levers in the OTT space—content, consumption, and monetisation. "Unlike most developed markets like the US that are largely homogeneous, in India and we at JioCinema, aim to provide content across screens, with personalisation being a big part of that strategy," he says. The obvious challenge is from a user point of view and that is safety related to online payments, which he says, "must be addressed to build trust and drive broader adoption".

Not surprisingly, the future of cinema, entertainment's pride and joy, is being closely tracked. "There is a clear space for it even as it competes for time and money against sports, eating out or content in oth-